

Primary Source Reading 1: Bentham's *Principles of Morals and Legislation*, Chapter I — Of the Principle of Utility

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 2.03 — The Greatest Happiness Principle By Jeremy Bentham (1789/1823)

Before you read: Bentham opens with one of the most quoted sentences in moral philosophy, then moves immediately to give the principle of utility a precise, technical definition. As you read, notice how insistent he is that this is not merely his personal preference but a description of an inescapable fact about human psychology — and watch for his definition of “the interest of the community,” which will matter for how utilitarian calculations are supposed to work.

Two Sovereign Masters

Nature has placed mankind under the governance of two sovereign masters, pain and pleasure. It is for them alone to point out what we ought to do, as well as to determine what we shall do. On the one hand the standard of right and wrong, on the other the chain of causes and effects, are fastened to their throne. They govern us in all we do, in all we say, in all we think: every effort we can make to throw off our subjection, will serve but to demonstrate and confirm it. In words a man may pretend to abjure their empire: but in reality he will remain subject to it all the while. The principle of utility recognizes this subjection, and assumes it for the foundation of that system, the object of which is to rear the fabric of felicity by the hands of reason and of law. Systems which attempt to question it, deal in sounds instead of sense, in caprice instead of reason, in darkness instead of light.

But enough of metaphor and declamation: it is not by such means that moral science is to be improved.

A Precise Definition

The principle of utility is the foundation of the present work: it will be proper therefore at the outset to give an explicit and determinate account of what is meant by it. By the principle of utility is meant that principle which approves or disapproves of every action whatsoever, according to the tendency it appears to have to augment or diminish the happiness of the party whose interest is in question: or, what is the same thing in other words, to promote or to oppose that happiness. I say of every action whatsoever, and therefore not only of every action of a private individual, but of every measure of government.

By utility is meant that property in any object, whereby it tends to produce benefit, advantage, pleasure, good, or happiness, (all this in the present case comes to the same thing) or (what comes again to the same thing) to prevent the happening of mischief, pain, evil, or unhappiness to the party whose interest is considered: if that

party be the community in general, then the happiness of the community: if a particular individual, then the happiness of that individual.

The Community Is a Fictitious Body

The interest of the community is one of the most general expressions that can occur in the phraseology of morals: no wonder that the meaning of it is often lost. When it has a meaning, it is this. The community is a fictitious body, composed of the individual persons who are considered as constituting as it were its members. The interest of the community then is, what? — the sum of the interests of the several members who compose it.

It is in vain to talk of the interest of the community, without understanding what is the interest of the individual. A thing is said to promote the interest, or to be for the interest, of an individual, when it tends to add to the sum total of his pleasures: or, what comes to the same thing, to diminish the sum total of his pains.

After you read: Notice how much work the phrase “the sum of the interests of the several members who compose it” is doing. Bentham defines the community’s interest as nothing more than an aggregate — the community has no interests of its own beyond the total of individual pleasures and pains added together. This is the assumption that makes it possible, at least in principle, to trade off one person’s pain against another’s pleasure: if the community is genuinely just a sum, then a policy that hurts one person badly but helps five people a little could still increase the total. Keep this definition in mind as you read Chapter IV, where Bentham tries to say exactly how such a sum would be calculated.